
Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

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Amorim gets his tactics spot on

The high-stakes duel in one of the fiercest rivalries in the English game came down to a crucial in-game management decision. Arne Slot, a manager lauded for smart substitutions last season, took a gamble in the 62nd minute, making three changes that aggressively shifted [Liverpool](#) into a 4-2-4, leaving Curtis Jones and Florian Wirtz dangerously exposed in midfield. The gamble initially appeared worthwhile: after rattling the post twice, Cody Gakpo finally delivered a 78th-minute equaliser to breathe some life into the deflated Anfield crowd. But Ruben Amorim remained calm and trusted his vision. Liverpool were undone just six minutes later after Bruno Fernandes's fantastic cross found Harry Maguire inexplicably alone at the far post, the lack of defensive bodies evident as he thumped in the winner. Slot was hoping for a high-risk, high-reward outcome but ultimately, United's grit in the second half paid off. Amorim has his critics – droves of them – but his tactics, including starting Maguire, were vindicated to earn United's first win at Anfield since 2016. Two league wins on the bounce is a first for Amorim at United. Are the wheels shifting? "It's an embarrassing stat to have had," said Maguire. "We have to start putting a bit more consistency together. We have set a benchmark." **Yara El-Shaboury**

Match report: [Liverpool 1-2 Manchester United](#)

2

Spurs struggle to paper over cracks

Tottenham began the day aiming to go second in the table, yet ended it pondering all-too familiar failings. Despite dominating for long periods Thomas Frank's side created few clearcut chances, reflecting their continued problems playing at home, where they have won just three of their last 18 league games, and taken only four points this season. Mohammed Kudus and Wilson Odobert are threatening from wide areas, but Xavi Simons has not settled and Mathys Tel looks raw, which suggests scoring goals will continue to be an issue, particularly against deep-lying defences. Were it not for an impressive haul of 10 points out of a possible 12 away from home the boos that greeted the final whistle would have been far louder. **Matt Hughes**

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Match report: [Tottenham 1-2 Aston Villa](#)

Gunners sharpen focus at Fulham

For [Arsenal](#) this was another day like all the others: the Kind Of Game You Just Have to Win To Be Champions. Maybe one day Arsenal will play a Game You Don't Have To Win, or a Game You Would Just Quite Like To Win. But not yet. There will be questions of course. One: is it boring to win like winning is everything when winning is everything (answer: no). And two, is there a case of Bukayo Saka dependence here? Saka was both brilliant against Fulham and also the only sharp creative element as Victor Gyökeres battered away and Eberechi Eze had a quiet day. It is hard to see too much wrong in channeling your main threat through a very good, very reliable academy-reared player. Could be worse eh? Plus Kai Havertz will be back next month and may play ahead of Gyökeres in The Super Vital Games You Really Really Have To Win. Behind all this the key stat is still one goal conceded from open play all season. This is how you win a league. And it's deceptively hard to do. **Barney Ronay**

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Match report: [Fulham 0-1 Arsenal](#)

Maresca swats away disciplinary issues

Ange Postecoglou's misery was Chelsea's satisfaction. Victory at [Nottingham Forest](#) was Chelsea's third in a row before hosting Ajax in the Champions League on Wednesday. The frustrating thing for Enzo Maresca was he had to watch from the directors' box, a few rows below Evangelos Marinakis, who departed the stadium at 2-0; Maresca served a touchline ban after being sent off against Liverpool and Malo Gusto's red card late on against Forest, after picking up a second yellow, raised further questions of ill-discipline. Chelsea have received five red cards in six matches, including Maresca's. The Italian argued there is context behind the sendings-off, in this case stating Gusto was desperate to keep a clean sheet, though in reality the versatile defender needlessly fouled Neco Williams midway inside the Forest half, with the hosts trailing 3-0 and going nowhere fast. "It is something we can do better, but I'm not concerned," Maresca said. "But, for sure, we can avoid it." **Ben Fisher**

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Match report: [Nottingham Forest 0-3 Chelsea](#)

Minteh shows what might have been

As Anthony Elanga struggled for Newcastle, a player who got away, Yankuba Minteh, showed what Eddie Howe missed out on. After struggling to meet profit and sustainability rules, Newcastle had to cash out Minteh to Brighton for £30m and Elliot Anderson to Nottingham Forest for £35m in the summer of 2024, a continued source of regret. Anderson has become an England regular and, even if Lewis Miley showed off his talents as a half-time sub, Newcastle's midfield department is bare beyond Sandro Tonali, Joelinton and Bruno Guimarães. Minteh is ideal for Fabian Hürzeler's high-pressing, quick transition game, his speed a surrogate for the absence of the injured Kaoru Mitoma. He would suit Newcastle, too. Dan Burn had a torrid afternoon against his old club; Minteh ran rings round the team he never played a match for. Coincidentally, his time on Newcastle's books included him impressing on loan at Arne Slot's Feyenoord. **John Brewin**

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Match report: [Brighton 2-1 Newcastle](#)

Guardiola runs rule over Rodri deputies

Pep Guardiola said Rodri's hamstring injury will continue to rule him out for Manchester City's next two games – at least. "I don't think [he will be available] for Villarreal or Aston Villa. It's not [for] long, but it's muscular and you have to be careful. We've tried so many times [to ease him back]. We've tried to not take a risk, but we have not been able to [prevent more setbacks]. So we will see," said the manager. To potentially deputise, Guardiola has the returning Mateo Kovacic, whose 86th-minute substitute appearance was a first for City this term after an achilles problem. "Kovacic has a special quality with the ball to keep it, but we cannot forget he came after surgery and a three or four month injury." Nico O'Reilly may also be unavailable for the Champions League trip to Villarreal. "A knock I think," said Guardiola. "We'll see." **Jamie Jackson**

Kroupi shows quality in striking style

In the absence of Evanilson with a calf injury that could also keep him out of next week's meeting with Nottingham Forest, Eli Junior Kroupi took his opportunity on his first league start by scoring twice against [Crystal Palace](#) in a 3-3 thriller that showed the 19-year-old could prove to be a shrewd investment. Signed from Bournemouth's sister club Lorient for around £12m and sent back on loan to finish as top scorer in Ligue 2 last season, the son of a prolific striker with the same first name, who helped the French side win the 2002 Coupe de France, already has three Premier League goals and also scored twice for France's Under-21s last week. "He's a goalscorer because he smells the chances," said the Bournemouth manager, Andoni Iraola. "He's someone who is very aware of the second balls, where the balls can finish. He's a good finisher. But obviously, he still has a lot of things to improve. The physicality, the rhythm, a lot of things that he has to learn." **Ed Aarons**

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Match report: [Crystal Palace 3-3 Bournemouth](#)

Mbeumo starting to make his mark

It had barely been a minute at Anfield before the controversy began. Bryan Mbeumo struck quickly for the visitors but, in the frantic buildup, Virgil van Dijk had elbowed his own teammate Alexis Mac Allister in the head while challenging Mbeumo for a header. Liverpool were furious as United celebrated in front of the Kop, arguing Michael Oliver should have stopped play under concussion protocol, though Van Dijk admitted post-match that "there was still plenty of football left to be

played". The opener cemented a purposefully aggressive start from [Manchester United](#) – a rarity from them at Anfield in recent years – and Mbeumo provided the high-intensity pressing and work ethic the club have desperately lacked. For a club heavily criticised for their recent transfer decisions, the 26-year-old is starting to look like an astute bit of business. **YE-S**

9

Pereira faces crucial test as woes resume

Will Wolves secure their first league win of the season at home to Burnley or at Fulham? If not, , the head coach, Vítor Pereira, could really be in trouble. In losing 2-0 to a once again impressive, upwardly mobile [Sunderland](#), it was telling that Wolves did not test Régis Le Bris's goalkeeper, Robin Roefs, until the 70th minute. Pereira admits that Jørgen Strand Larsen is "struggling". The Norway striker is without a league goal this season but, in mitigation, a player disappointed not to join Newcastle in August is carrying an achilles injury and barely able to train between games. Pereira, meanwhile, remains convinced his defensively fragile team will come good. "If in one minute of my work I feel that my players are not with me, that is the end, but I didn't feel it," he said. "I feel they are frustrated but this is a moment when I need to help them." **Louise Taylor**

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Match report: [Sunderland 2-0 Wolves](#)

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Burnley reap rewards of Florentino move

It was a very busy summer at Burnley as they invested heavily in the hope of building a squad capable of staying in the [Premier League](#). Someone was effectively signed for every position; the final arrival was Florentino Luís on deadline from Benfica. The Portuguese midfielder was a shining light in the club's academy and it was thought he would follow in the footsteps of Bernardo Silva and Rúben Dias by making a big-money move but Florentino's career had stalled somewhat. Loan

moves to Monaco and Getafe did not work out, so he returned to Benfica, needing to prove himself once more, doing so domestically and in the Champions League. At 26, Burnley saw the right attributes; he is energetic, comfortable in possession and rarely panics even in tight situations. His contributions have been impressive thus far. He looks to be a smart acquisition. **Will Unwin**

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Match report: [Burnley 2-0 Leeds](#)

Pos	Team	P	GD	Pts
1	Arsenal	8	12	19
2	Man City	8	11	16
3	AFC Bournemouth	8	3	15
4	Liverpool	8	3	15
5	Chelsea	8	7	14
6	Tottenham Hotspur	8	7	14
7	Sunderland	8	3	14
8	Crystal Palace	8	4	13
9	Man Utd	8	-1	13
10	Brighton	8	1	12
11	Aston Villa	8	0	12
12	Everton	8	0	11
13	Newcastle	8	0	9
14	Fulham	8	-4	8
15	Leeds	8	-6	8
16	Brentford	7	-3	7
17	Burnley	8	-6	7
18	Nottm Forest	8	-10	5
19	West Ham	7	-10	4
20	Wolverhampton	8	-11	2

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